Public Opinion on AI

Measuring Trust, Awareness, and Attitudes Toward Artificial Intelligence

Original survey design, weighted topline analysis, and demographic crosstabulation of American public attitudes toward AI.

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Methodology: Qualtrics survey, stratified sampling, post-stratification raking weights

Executive Summary

This report presents an original survey measuring how the American public perceives, trusts, and engages with artificial intelligence. The survey was designed from the ground up — research question, sampling plan, and a 25-item questionnaire — then fielded via Qualtrics and analyzed using post-stratification weighting to bring the sample in line with national demographic benchmarks.

Three findings anchor the results. First, self-reported AI knowledge splits the public roughly into thirds, with a pronounced generational divide: younger adults report far higher familiarity than older adults. Second, sentiment toward AI's integration into daily life is mixed-to-positive, with a substantial neutral segment suggesting many people remain undecided rather than opposed. Third, and most decisively, transparency is a near-universal expectation — 78% of respondents rate clear explanations of how AI systems reach decisions as “Extremely” or “Very” important, with this preference even stronger among respondents without a college degree.

Together, these results suggest that public hesitation about AI is less about outright rejection and more about a trust gap rooted in opacity — a gap that widens along generational and educational lines.

Background & Research Objectives

As AI systems become embedded across institutions — from healthcare to finance to everyday consumer tools — understanding how the public perceives and trusts these systems has become essential for both product design and policy. This survey was motivated by three questions:

- How much trust do people place in AI systems to deliver reliable information?
- What external factors — demographic or experiential — influence that trust?
- What concerns keep people from fully trusting AI systems?

Prior research frames this territory well. Pew Research Center (2023) found 52% of U.S. adults expressed concern about AI's growing role in daily life, versus only 10% expressing excitement — with acceptance varying sharply by use case (more comfort with AI in shopping than in healthcare). Glikson & Woolley (2020) identified individual traits like propensity to trust and affinity for technology as consistent predictors of AI trust. KPMG and the University of Queensland (2023) emphasized that regulation and transparency are central levers for public confidence, a theme echoed by Amazon Web Services (2023), which found 83% of public-sector respondents cited trust as a significant barrier to adopting generative AI.

Study Design

Design Element	Approach
Population	American adults, spanning age, education, gender, race, and prior AI exposure
Sampling approach	Stratified random sampling, with older adults oversampled to capture generational differences in comfort with technology
Recruitment	Online recruitment via social media and survey panels, supplemented by community outreach for offline populations
Survey mode	Online, administered through Qualtrics

Design Element	Approach
Target sample size	400–600 respondents, sized to detect differences in trust across demographic subgroups
Consent	Informed consent obtained from all respondents prior to participation, with explicit assurances of confidentiality and data protection

Measures

Dependent variables: trust in AI systems to deliver accurate information; broader attitudes toward AI's integration into daily life.

Independent variables: familiarity with AI (frequency of use, self-rated understanding, information sources); demographic factors (age, education).

The 25-item questionnaire used a mix of 5-point Likert scales for attitudinal questions and multiple-choice for usage and awareness questions, organized to move respondents from simple familiarity questions into broader attitudes, and finally into more complex transparency and regulatory concerns.

Weighting Methodology

Raw survey responses were adjusted using post-stratification raking weights, targeting national population benchmarks across five dimensions: age group, gender, race, Hispanic origin, and college education. Weights were computed using the anesrake algorithm in R, which converged in 37 iterations. The resulting weight distribution (min 0.20, mean 0.76–1.09 depending on specification, max 7.00) was reviewed to confirm no single respondent was disproportionately influencing topline estimates. All results below reflect weighted estimates unless otherwise noted.

Weighted Topline Results

Respondent Knowledge of Artificial Intelligence

Knowledge Level	N	% Selected
Extremely knowledgeable	27	10%
Very knowledgeable	48	18%
Somewhat knowledgeable	89	34%
Not very knowledgeable	82	31%
Not knowledgeable at all	20	8%

Full sample MOE ± 6%

Self-reported AI knowledge is roughly normally distributed: 34% call themselves “somewhat knowledgeable,” with 28% leaning more knowledgeable and 39% leaning less so. A meaningful share of the public still doesn't feel equipped to evaluate AI systems, even as those systems become more common.

“The integration of AI into our daily life is a good thing overall”

Agree or Disagree	N	% Selected
Strongly agree	49	19%
Somewhat agree	68	26%
Neither agree nor disagree	75	28%
Somewhat disagree	37	14%
Strongly disagree	36	13%

Full sample MOE ± 6%

Sentiment leans positive (45% agree vs. 27% disagree) but a sizeable 28% neutral segment signals real ambivalence rather than settled opinion — a group that could move either direction depending on future experience or communication.

Importance of Clear Explanations from AI Systems

Level of Importance	N	% Selected
Extremely important	73	41%
Very important	67	37%
Somewhat important	33	18%
Not very important	6	3%
Not at all important	1	0%

Full sample MOE ± 6%

This is the report's clearest signal: 78% of respondents consider clear, explainable AI decision-making “Extremely” or “Very” important, with only 3% dismissing it. Transparency isn't a niche preference — it's close to a baseline expectation.

Demographic Crosstabulations

AI Knowledge by Age Group

Knowledge Level	18–25	26–34	35–54	55–64	65+
Extremely knowledgeable	28	15	11	0	3
Very knowledgeable	35	42	18	7	2
Somewhat knowledgeable	28	35	41	33	25
Not very knowledgeable	8	8	26	46	53
Not knowledgeable at all	0	0	4	15	16
n	**30**	**43**	**89**	**45**	**60**

Full sample MOE ± 6%; values represent percentage per knowledge level within age group

The generational divide is stark. 63% of 18–25-year-olds and 57% of 26–34-year-olds rate themselves “Extremely” or “Very” knowledgeable about AI, and zero respondents under 35 selected “Not knowledgeable at all.” Among adults 55 and older, the pattern reverses sharply: 61% of 55–64-year-olds and 69% of those 65+ report being “Not very” or “Not at all” knowledgeable. This gap points to a concrete opportunity for targeted AI literacy efforts aimed at older adults.

Importance of Clear AI Explanations by Education

Level of Importance	No College Education	College Education
Extremely important	54%	33%
Very important	28%	43%
Somewhat important	16%	20%
Not very important	3%	4%
Not at all important	0%	1%
n	**65**	**114**

Full sample MOE ± 6%; values represent percentage per selected level

Both groups strongly value explainability — 82% among those without a college degree, 76% among those with one — but respondents without a college education are notably more likely to rate it “Extremely” rather than “Very” important (54% vs. 33%). This suggests explainability isn't just a technically sophisticated audience's concern; if anything, it matters most to those with fewer independent means of evaluating an AI system's reasoning.

Conclusion & Recommendations

This survey's central finding is that public hesitation toward AI is driven less by categorical rejection and more by a trust gap tied to transparency. Sentiment toward AI's role in daily life is mixed rather than hostile, but the near-universal demand for clear explanations — and the sharper version of that demand among respondents without a college degree — suggests organizations deploying AI-driven products and services would benefit from investing in explainability as a trust-building tool, not just a compliance requirement.

The generational knowledge gap identified in the crosstabulations also points to a distinct opportunity: targeted AI literacy initiatives for older adults could close a familiarity gap that, left unaddressed, risks compounding existing disparities in trust and comfort with new technology.

Future Directions

This project raised further questions worth investigating in follow-up work: how cultural background shapes trust in AI, what role media coverage plays in shaping public attitudes, and how organizations can most effectively communicate AI system capabilities and limitations to build durable public confidence.

References

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